



MANUFACTURED REALITY



Manufactured Reality

How three actors in the Eastern DRC conflict weaponised information infrastructure to fight a war before and alongside the soldiers

JULY 2026

EDITOR'S NOTE

This report was produced from a dataset of 2,012 posts collected from a single platform over twelve weeks. That is a narrow window onto a war that has displaced hundreds of thousands of people, and we want to be clear at the outset about what it can and cannot support.

It can support a behavioural finding. The network is assessed as aligned with the Rwandan government and M23 messaging at high confidence; as directly tasked by a state organ at low-to-medium. That gap is the boundary of what public data can establish, not a hedge, and readers who collapse it will be reading something we did not publish.

The report documents three operations, including the Congolese government's own campaign. This is not a verdict on the war. The material at issue is largely not false; the argument is about what was done with facts once their context was stripped. And the named handles are assessed as inauthentic assets, not as identified people.

The report's sharpest claim is that the standard instrument for measuring influence operations, diffusion, reach, and breakout, is the wrong instrument here, and that an operation reaching almost nobody can still be doing its job. That claim is contestable. We publish it because the alternative is a monitoring environment in which this class of operation is scored as a failure and filed.

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ABSTRACT

Between January and March 2025, the M23 armed movement captured Goma and Bukavu, the two largest cities in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo. The fall of those cities triggered the most intense diplomatic period of the conflict, drawing in the United Nations Security Council, the European Union, the United States, and Qatari mediators. Alongside the fighting on the ground, a parallel battle was waged over how these events would be interpreted by the institutions with the authority to sanction, condemn, or legitimize.

This report analyses 2,012 posts collected from X (formerly Twitter) across twelve hashtags between January 2 and March 30, 2025. It identifies and assesses three distinct, organised campaigns operating simultaneously within the same information space: a covert pro-Rwanda network of approximately 90 accounts that promoted five anti-Tshisekedi hashtags in four coordinated waves aligned with key diplomatic decision points; a single-operator account engaged in sustained hashtag flooding against the Rwandan government; and the Congolese government's overt mobilisation campaign, CongolaisTelema, which was both targeted and exploited by the other two operations.

The report's central finding concerns the direction of the covert network's fire. Its purpose was not to persuade the general public but to place a counter-narrative directly in front of two institutional accounts, @UN and @EUCouncil, in the very weeks those institutions were deciding on sanctions. That this is a coordinated, inauthentic network rather than organic activism is established by strong behavioural evidence: machine-speed burst posting, stray script line numbers in published posts, synchronised multi-account activation, and wave timing correlated with EU and UN decision windows. But coordination is the means, not the point. What distinguishes the operation is that its narratives, closely aligned with the strategic messaging of the Rwandan government and M23, were addressed to decision-makers at the moment of decision rather than to the Congolese or Rwandan publics. By conventional engagement metrics the operation appears to have failed, generating 2.1 percent of the dataset's total views. This report argues that engagement is the wrong instrument for this class of operation, and that decision-point targeting of international institutions is a distinct category of impact that existing influence operation frameworks do not adequately capture.

The case is situated within the broader context of documented pro-Rwanda influence operations, the structural limitations of the Great Lakes FIMI monitoring environment, and the constraints of fact-checking as a counter-narrative instrument. In particular, it highlights the challenge posed by manipulation strategies that rely not on falsehoods, but on selectively framed truths disseminated through constructed personas.

Keywords: *foreign information manipulation and interference (FIMI), coordinated inauthentic behaviour, influence operations, Great Lakes, Democratic Republic of Congo, Rwanda, M23, X (Twitter), hashtag hijacking, decision-point targeting*

INTRODUCTION

The War and the Information War

On 25 January 2025, Denise Nyakeru Tshisekedi, First Lady of the Democratic Republic of Congo, visited the wards of Camp Kokolo and Tshatshi Military Hospital in Kinshasa. The men in those beds had been wounded during the M23 offensive the previous week, in which rebel forces captured Goma, the largest city in eastern Congo and home to more than a million people. The visit was documented and circulated by Congolese state media: the nation's first lady at the bedside of the country's soldiers.

On X, a different version of the same visit circulated in parallel. Rwanda's Foreign Minister, Olivier Nduhungerehe, posted photographs from the hospital wards and claimed the wounded men included fighters from the CRAP unit (Commando de Recherche et d'Action en Profondeur) of the FDLR, the Forces Démocratiques de Liberation du Rwanda, an armed group founded by perpetrators of the 1994 genocide against the Tutsi. He argued that the visit was proof that the Congolese government was openly integrating and supporting a genocidal militia at the highest levels. The minister's post was the most visible. A similar argument was reproduced across dozens of accounts using the hashtag #TshisekediFDLR, in bursts that, on closer inspection, were not organic at all.

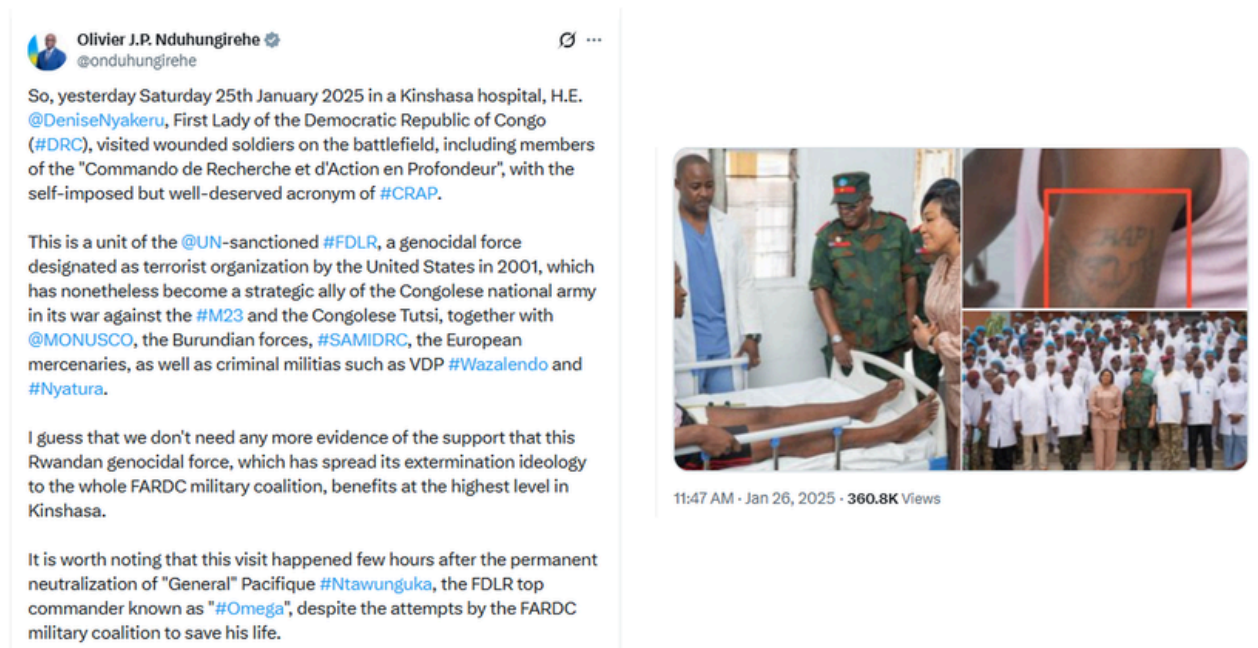


Figure 1: Screenshot of tweet by Rwanda's Foreign Minister, Olivier Nduhungerehe

The narrative surrounding the First Lady's hospital visit was not primarily addressed to Congolese citizens. It was addressed to institutions in New York and Brussels with the power to sanction, condemn, and legitimise.

That contradiction, one event producing two entirely different information products aimed at entirely different audiences, offers a precise specimen of what information warfare looks like inside an active interstate conflict. Alongside the fighting on the ground, a parallel battle is waged over how events are perceived, and critically, by whom.

The roots of this parallel conflict run deep, stemming from the 1994 genocide against the Tutsi, the flight of its perpetrators into eastern Congo, and three decades of cross-border insurgency. The Background section provides a detailed account of this history and the diplomatic escalations of early 2025. What is significant here is that by January 2025, both sides of the conflict were conducting information campaigns alongside their military and diplomatic efforts. This report examines what transpired when those narratives were implemented on a large scale on platform X: who was involved, the mechanisms used, and the target audiences.

FIMI in Active Conflict

Foreign information manipulation and interference (FIMI), defined as coordinated efforts to manipulate information environments, distort public debate, and influence political outcomes through deceptive or inauthentic means, is conventionally studied in the context of elections in Europe and North America.^{[1][2]} Within this literature, emphasis is frequently placed on mass audiences, voter behaviour, and the amplification of false or misleading content at scale.

The case documented here differs in ways that are both analytically significant and, we argue, increasingly typical. It concerns information manipulation deployed within an active interstate conflict, in a region where platform trust and safety investment is limited, fact-checking capacity is overwhelmed, and the primary audience is not a voting public but the small set of institutions whose decisions determine the cost of military aggression. This is FIMI as a component of war-fighting, and the Great Lakes region is one of its least monitored theatres.

This report does not document the first pro-Rwanda influence operation on record. Rather, it adds a behaviourally evidenced case to a growing body of documented activity. The prior work was the June 2024 report by the Clemson University Media Forensics Hub, which identified an AI-enabled, RPF-aligned coordinated network of at least 464 accounts on X that produced more than 650,000 posts from January 2024 onward, with the DRC conflict as its dominant content theme. That study established the scale and persistence of pro-Rwanda networked activity within the platform environment.

This report extends that record in three specific ways. First, it isolates a discrete operational network and demonstrates coordination through behavioural indicators, such as synchronised posting, burst activity, and timing alignment, rather than relying on content similarity alone. Second, it links the network's activity waves to specific diplomatic decision points, showing how information operations can be temporally structured around moments of institutional vulnerability. Third, it documents the simultaneous presence of three competing campaigns within a single hashtag ecosystem, highlighting a structural feature of conflict-era information environments in which multiple actors, state-aligned, oppositional, and domestic, operate concurrently and interactively.

[1. 4th EEAS Report on Foreign Information Manipulation and Interference Threats](#)

[2. North America Regional Hub: Foreign Information Manipulations and Interference](#)

BACKGROUND

The tensions between Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of Congo are not new. Their contemporary form is rooted in the events of 1994. Over approximately one hundred days, an estimated 800,000 people, the majority of them Tutsi, were killed in Rwanda in one of the fastest acts of mass murder in recorded history. The Hutu militias responsible fled across the border into what was then Zaire, settling in the east, keeping their weapons and command structures intact. The armed groups that later consolidated in those eastern forests became the FDLR, a movement rooted in the same ideology that drove the genocide, recruiting across generations and financing itself through the region's mineral trade.³

For Kigali, that proximity has never stopped being a live security concern.

M23, the March 23 Movement, is the latest iteration of this cycle. Led primarily by Congolese Tutsi commanders and fighters, many with prior affiliations to earlier Rwanda-backed rebel movements such as the CNDP (National Congress for the Defence of the People), M23 first emerged in 2012 following a mutiny within the Congolese army. The group briefly captured Goma that same year before being militarily defeated and going dormant. It re-emerged in late 2021, with renewed capacity, significantly improved organisation, discipline, and access to advanced weaponry, and has since expanded its territorial control across North Kivu, including key supply routes and border zones. UN reporting and independent analyses have estimated the group's strength at the low thousands, with the capacity to rapidly mass forces along key axes of advance. The question of Rwanda's relationship to M23 sits at the centre of every diplomatic confrontation over this conflict. The United Nations Group of Experts, the United States, the European Union, and Human Rights Watch have all presented evidence of direct Rwandan military support, including troop deployments, weapons supply, and command coordination. Rwanda has formally and consistently denied it.

By January 2025, that dispute had reached a breaking point. The fall of Goma on January 27 and Bukavu on February 16 triggered the most intensive diplomatic period of the conflict: US sanctions on Rwandan and M23 officials (February 20), UN Security Council Resolution 2773 demanding the withdrawal of Rwandan forces (February 21), an EU sanctions process that stalled on February 24 and concluded on March 17 with designations of nine Rwandan and M23 figures, and a surprise meeting between Presidents Tshisekedi and Kagame in Doha on March 18, brokered by Qatar.

3. [M23 Leverages Taxes and Minerals to Sustain DRC Operations](#)

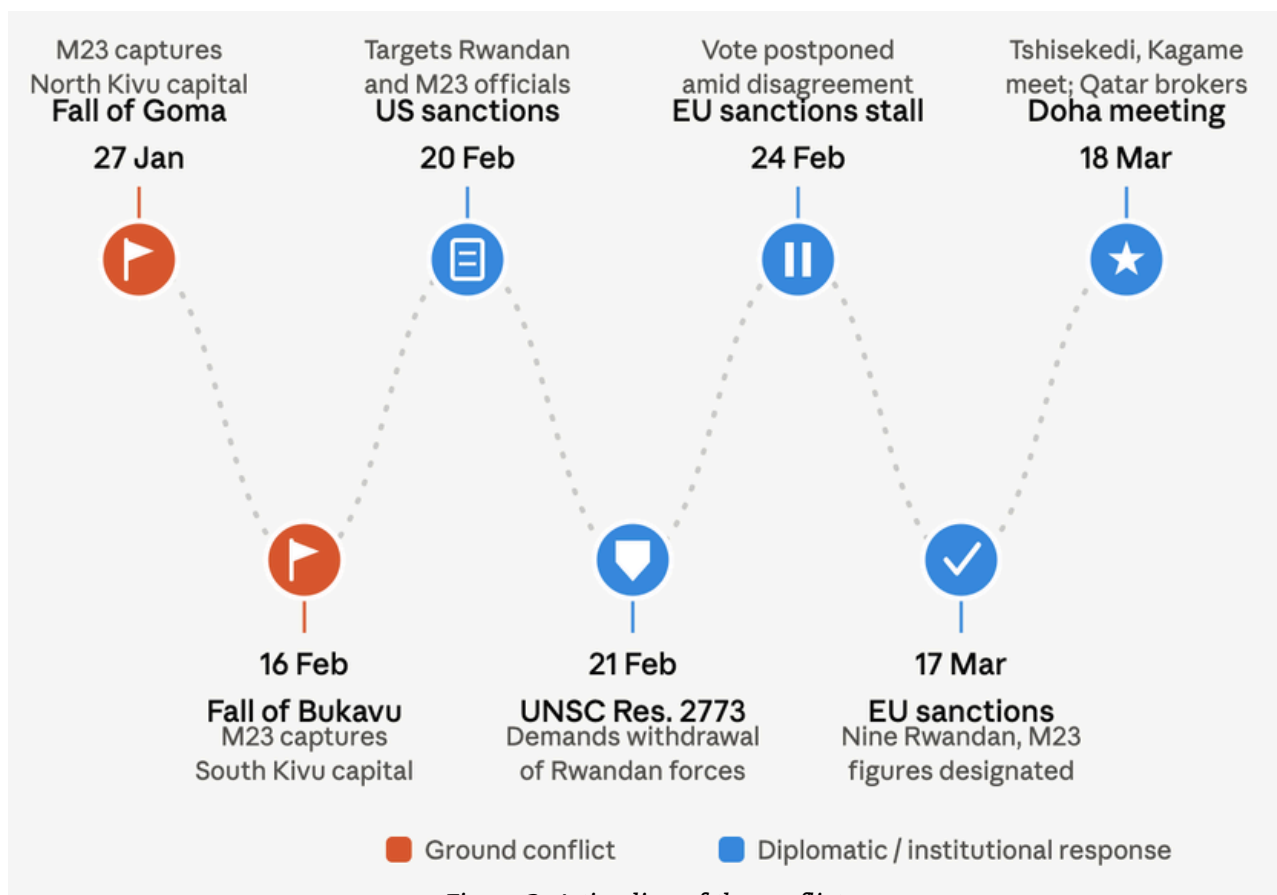


Figure 2: A timeline of the conflict

Each side of the war ran an information campaign alongside its military and diplomatic effort. The Congolese government launched *CongolaisTelema* (Lingala for "Congolese, stand up"), a patriotic mobilisation campaign fronted by Communications Minister Patrick Muyaya, carried on national broadcaster RTNC, and structured around army recruitment, a cultural front of musicians and slam poets, and provincial tours by Prime Minister Judith Suminwa. Rwanda and M23 pressed two core narratives in every diplomatic venue: that the Congolese army is integrated with the FDLR, and that the DRC government persecutes its Tutsi and Banyamulenge citizens. Both narratives have a documented factual substrate. This report examines what occurred when these narratives were operationalised at scale on X, by whom, through what mechanisms, and directed at which audiences.

Foreign Interests and the Conflict Economy

The wars of the Kivus have never been a purely regional affair. Eastern Congo's mineral wealth has consistently drawn foreign commercial and security networks whose activity shaped the battlefield while remaining largely invisible to the publics and institutions deliberating over the conflict. The defeat of M23's first insurgency offers a documented example. Records released under the United States' Epstein Files Transparency Act, together with hacked correspondence of former Israeli Prime Minister Ehud Barak reported by Drop Site News in June 2026, show that the network of financier Jeffrey Epstein operated on both the military and commercial sides of the 2013 war.

Global Strategic Group, a private military firm run by former Mossad director Danny Yatom and marketed through Barak, a close Epstein associate, trained a Congolese special operations unit in the mineral-rich east in 2013 and later claimed its work had helped turn the tide against M23. In the same months, Epstein's associate Sultan Ahmed bin Sulayem, then chairman of DP World, was opening a direct channel to President Joseph Kabila over investments in mining, oil, gas, and port infrastructure, and offered in the released correspondence to broker meetings for Epstein with the presidents of the DRC, Rwanda, Gabon, Senegal, and Kenya. By 2018, Epstein was involved in sanctions diplomacy surrounding the US Treasury's designation of an Israeli mining magnate profiting from Congolese conflict minerals.

The Barak correspondence originates in a hack-and-leak attributed to Handala, a group with suspected links to Iranian intelligence, distributed via Distributed Denial of Secrets and independently vetted by the journalists who reported it. This is consistent with the source-critical standards applied throughout this report; we treat it as corroborating rather than primary evidence and note that appearing in the released files does not in itself establish wrongdoing by any Congolese, Rwandan, or other official.

The implication, however, is directly relevant to what follows. The contest over eastern Congo's resources has long been conducted through deniable intermediaries, private military trainers, port conglomerates, and fixers, whose influence was exercised at decision points, away from public view, by actors whose sponsorship is difficult to attribute. The information operations documented in this report follow the same logic.

January to March 2025: Military Collapse and Diplomatic Escalation

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The Information Campaigns

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Prior Documented Pro-Rwanda Influence Operations

This report does not document the first pro-Rwanda influence operation on record. The most substantial prior work is the June 2024 report by the Clemson University Media Forensics Hub, which identified an AI-enabled, RPF-aligned coordinated network of at least 464 accounts on X that produced more than 650,000 posts from January 2024 onward, with the DRC conflict as its dominant content theme. That study established the scale and persistence of pro-Rwanda networked activity within the platform environment.

The Clemson study is not an isolated finding. In May 2024, the Forbidden Stories consortium's Rwanda Classified investigation documented a broader Rwandan apparatus for transnational repression and narrative control, and in March 2025 the Belgian public broadcaster VRT identified an AI-assisted pro-Rwanda online campaign targeting Belgium in the same weeks that the EU sanctions decision, and the rupture of Rwanda–Belgium relations, played out. Set against this pattern of documented activity is a monitoring environment with almost no dedicated capacity: the analyst networks, rapid alert systems, and platform trust and safety investment that surround European and North American elections have no Great Lakes equivalent. That asymmetry, between a persistent set of documented operations and a thinly defended information space, is the environment in which the campaigns analysed in this report took place.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

Data Collection

The dataset was collected from X (formerly Twitter) under twelve predefined hashtags and keyword collection tags relating to the eastern DRC conflict. These tags were selected to capture three overlapping layers of the information environment: (1) general conflict discourse (e.g., rdc, goma, m23, rwanda, fdlr, rdf), (2) campaign-specific hashtags associated with anti-Tshisekedi narratives, and (3) tags linked to identifiable mobilisation efforts such as CongolaisTelema. This approach allows the dataset to capture both organic discussion and coordinated campaign activity within the same analytical frame. After the removal of 110 duplicate rows, the final analysed dataset contains 2,012 unique posts from 794 unique account handles published between January 2 and March 30, 2025, with 3.46 million combined views. Each record includes full text, post URL, timestamp, engagement metrics (views, likes, retweets, replies, quotes, bookmarks), language, and author metadata (display name, bio, follower and following counts, declared location, verification status).

Collection tag	Posts	Accounts	Posts per account	Campaign grouping
rdc	336	215	1.6	CongolaisTelema and general DRC conversation
rwanda	216	141	1.5	Mixed conflict conversation
tshisekediiskilling	212	44	4.8	Covert anti-Tshisekedi network
tshisekediagainstepeace	200	33	6.1	Covert anti-Tshisekedi network
rubavu	181	49	3.7	Dominated by anti-Kagame flooder account
m23	179	130	1.4	Mixed conflict conversation
tshisekedifdlr	168	19	8.8	Covert anti-Tshisekedi network
fdlr	165	107	1.5	Mixed conflict conversation
rdf	163	93	1.8	Mixed conflict conversation
goma	160	134	1.2	Mixed conflict conversation
disarmfdlr	29	10	2.9	Covert anti-Tshisekedi network
tshisekedicriminal	3	2	1.5	Anti-Tshisekedi (Congolese opposition framing)

Table 1: Dataset composition by collection tag after deduplication. The posts-per-account ratio is the first coordination indicator visible in the raw data: organic conversation tags cluster between 1.2 and 1.8; the five anti-Tshisekedi tags run between 2.9 and 8.8

Analytical Framework

The analysis follows the actors–behaviour–content (ABC) framework widely used in FIMI and influence operations research. This approach disaggregates activity into three components: the accounts involved (actors), the observable patterns of activity (behaviour), and the narratives or claims being advanced (content). In line with current best practice, this report prioritises behavioural indicators of coordination, such as synchronised posting, burst activity, repetition patterns, and timing alignment, over content similarity alone, which may reflect organic agreement or shared information environments rather than coordinated action.

Techniques identified in the dataset are mapped to the DISARM Red framework, an open-source taxonomy of influence operation tactics, techniques, and procedures (TTPs) used by the EU External Action Service (EEAS), NATO, and related practitioner communities. This mapping enables consistent classification of observed behaviours within a broader comparative framework and situates the case within established FIMI typologies.

A key analytical focus is temporal alignment: the extent to which coordinated activity corresponds to identifiable external events, particularly diplomatic decision points. This report treats such alignment as a distinct indicator of strategic intent, especially where activity clusters tightly around known institutional processes.

Attribution judgments are made using explicit estimative language and are grounded in observable behavioural evidence rather than assumed intent. This report does not claim definitive attribution in the intelligence sense; instead, it assesses alignment, coordination, and likelihood based on available data.

Confidence levels follow standard estimative practice. High confidence indicates conclusions supported by multiple, independent, and mutually reinforcing lines of evidence. Medium confidence indicates that the evidence is suggestive but allows for plausible alternative explanations. Low confidence indicates that a judgment is plausible but not conclusively demonstrated by the available data.

Limitations

The dataset is keyword-based and therefore captures only posts containing the selected hashtags and terms, not the full activity of any given account. All counts relating to networks or campaigns should therefore be understood as minimum estimates rather than comprehensive totals.

Collection density is uneven across time. General conflict tags (rdc, goma, m23, rwanda, fdlr, rdf) are heavily concentrated in the final week of March, while the anti-Tshisekedi campaign tags span the full collection period. As a result, cross-tag volume comparisons are indicative rather than strictly comparable.

Several relevant variables are unavailable.

Account creation dates are not included; follower counts represent a snapshot at the time of collection; and content deleted prior to collection is not captured. No platform-internal data, such as IP addresses, device identifiers, login telemetry, or registration details, is accessible. All findings are therefore derived from publicly observable signals.

This constraint defines the evidentiary limits of external FIMI research. The distinction between what can be inferred from behavioural analysis and what can be confirmed through platform-level data remains a persistent gap. This report makes that boundary explicit and treats attribution claims accordingly

ANALYSIS AND FINDINGS

This section documents three distinct operations occupying a shared information space. They differ in actor type, technique, sponsor alignment, intended audience, and theory of influence. Treating them as a single coordinated effort would obscure these differences; treating them as unrelated would miss a central structural feature of contemporary conflict information environments: multiple, competing operations can simultaneously inhabit the same hashtag ecosystem, each shaping visibility and interpretation in different ways.

In this case, a government mobilisation campaign, a covert coordinated network, and a single high-volume individual actor all operated within the same searchable space, interacting indirectly through hashtag overlap and narrative contestation.

Operation 1: The Anti-Tshisekedi Burst Network

Five collection tags (tshisekediiskilling, tshisekediagainstone, tshisekedifdlr, tshisekedicriminel, disarmfdlr) yield 612 posts from 90 unique accounts. This network represents 11 percent of the accounts in the dataset but produced 30 percent of all content, while capturing only 2.1 percent of total views.

This disproportion, high output, minimal engagement, is consistent with an operation optimised for visibility at specific targets rather than broad audience reach

Account Composition

The account inventory is consistent with a low-cost, disposable-asset operation rather than an audience-building strategy. Median follower count is 424. One third of accounts have fewer than 100 followers, 56 percent have fewer than 500.

Thirteen accounts (14 percent) still carry the platform's auto-generated handle pattern of a name followed by a long numeric string, indicating the operator never customised the handle after registration. This is a common characteristic of accounts not intended for long-term identity building.

At least 10 accounts display explicit affinity markers associated with the Rwandan Patriotic Front (RPF) in their names or bios including the use of #TeamPK (Team Paul Kagame) or "Inkotanyi", a term historically associated with RPF cadres. Of the 55 accounts that declaring a location, 37 (67 percent) list Rwanda or nearby border regions, particularly Kisoro in Uganda. A further 35 accounts provide no location data.

Taken together, these features suggest a network composed of low-investment accounts with limited concern for authenticity signalling beyond minimal ideological alignment.

Handle	Posts	Followers	Location	Activity pattern
Struggles_23 (Amahoro Eliot)	66	340	(none)	28 active days, Feb 3 to Mar 30; only account active in all four waves
Claudeniyonku 10	53	166	Kigali	32 posts Feb 4, 21 posts Feb 6, then silent
TuyisengeD227 48	28	18	(none)	28 posts in 7.8 minutes, Feb 28
lisedes20 (Ruta Lise)	24	22	Belgique	Persistent low volume, Feb 2 to Mar 25
NKOTANYI1_	21	8	(none)	21 posts in 30 seconds, Feb 28
FrancoisOb170 5	20	13	"Location"	20 posts in 2.6 minutes, Feb 4
WAKASE__2	20	63	Kigali	20 posts in 3.3 minutes, Feb 5
e_lucaton	20	137	(none)	20 posts in 9.8 minutes, Feb 4
bakundifura	20	3,168	Rwanda	20 posts in 3.6 hours, Mar 1; bio tags @TeamPK
MooniPeter	10	142	Republique du Rwanda	10 posts in 11 seconds, Mar 15

Table 2. Most active network accounts. The activity pattern column is the primary coordination indicator for each account.

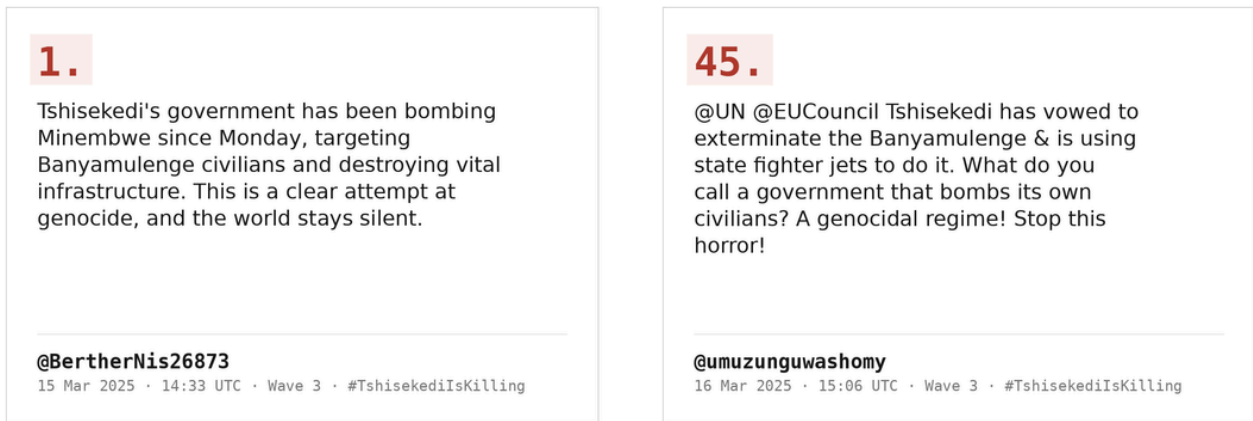
Behavioural Evidence of Coordination

The single strongest coordination signal is inter-post timing. Multiple accounts published their entire quarterly output within compressed windows of seconds to minutes—at rates exceeding plausible human composition. In several cases, multiple posts share identical timestamps to the second. These patterns are consistent with centrally prepared content distributed for rapid posting, either through manual copy-paste workflows or light automation.

Handle	Posts	Window	Rate	Date	Hashtag
MooniPeter	10	11 seconds	55 posts/min	Mar 15	#Tshisekedi IsKilling
NKOTANYI1 –	21	30 seconds	42 posts/min	Feb 28	#Tshisekedi AgainstPeac e
FrancoisOb1 705	20	2.6 minutes	7.6 posts/min	Feb 4	#Tshisekedi FDLR
umuzungu washomy	10	2.1 minutes	4.7 posts/min	Mar 16	#Tshisekedi IsKilling
WAKASE__2	20	3.3 minutes	6.1 posts/min	Feb 5	#Tshisekedi FDLR
jeanpauloffi cia	10	3.6 minutes	2.8 posts/min	Mar 15	#Tshisekedi IsKilling
TuyisengeD 22748	28	7.8 minutes	3.6 posts/min	Feb 28	#Tshisekedi AgainstPeac e
MCishakuri 26676	16	7.8 minutes	2.1 posts/min	Feb 28	#Tshisekedi AgainstPeac e
e_lucaton	20	9.8 minutes	2.0 posts/min	Feb 4	#Tshisekedi FDLR

Table 3. Burst posting evidence. Each row represents one account's complete activity in a single sitting. Rates above 2 posts per minute are inconsistent with independent human composition.

Two accounts additionally published posts that still carried the line numbers of the master document from which the content was copied. This is direct, content-level evidence that posts were drafted centrally, enumerated, and distributed to posting accounts:



Entries 1 and 45 of the same master document, posted 24 hours apart by two accounts.

Figure 3. Dataset records, rendered from collected text, not platform captures

A master list running to at least 45 numbered entries implies a content volume substantially larger than what this collection captured for that wave. It implies that additional accounts posting from the same script likely exist outside the collection.

Synchronised account activation reinforces the picture. On the morning of February 28, accounts NKOTANYI1_, TuyisengeD22748, MCishakuri26676, F_Hagenimana, BizimanaGratien and Saidi74224560 all began posting within a two-hour window (08:24 to 10:40 UTC), each producing 10 to 28 posts on the same hashtag pair (#TshisekediAgainstPeace #UNSecurityCouncil). A similar pattern occurred on March 15, when 25 accounts were active within a single day using #TshisekediIsKilling. Taken together, these behavioural patterns indicate an operation optimised not for audience engagement but for visibility at specific institutional targets. The combination of burst posting, synchronised activation, and centrally distributed messaging suggests a model designed to saturate hashtags at precise moments, particularly those aligned with diplomatic decision windows. This differs from conventional influence operations that seek to build reach or persuasion among broad publics. Instead, the observed activity is consistent with a form of decision-point targeting, in which volume and timing are used to insert specific narratives into the information streams monitored by international organisations. In this model, low engagement is not a failure condition but an expected outcome of a campaign oriented toward elite rather than mass audiences.

Wave Structure: Four Campaigns Timed to Four Decisions

The network did not post at a steady rate. Approximately 80 percent of its output falls within four short waves, each coinciding with a specific event in the diplomatic calendar. Across these waves, the lead hashtag rotates, a pattern consistent with campaign tasking organised in discrete phases rather than continuous activity.

Wave	Dates	Posts / Accounts	Lead hashtag	Targeted event	Core narrative
1	Feb 2-6	143 / 12	#Tshisekedi FDLR	First Lady visits wounded FARDC soldiers; M23/RDF claim FDLR commanders killed in Goma operation	The wounded men are FDLR fighters; the visit proves FARDC and FDLR are one force
2	Feb 28-Mar 1	145 / 20	#Tshisekedi AgainstPeace + #UNSecurityCouncil	Week after UNSC Resolution 2773; four days after EU postponed sanctions vote	UN and EU are sanctioning the wrong side; Tshisekedi stalls the Luanda process
3	Mar 15-16	163 / 32	#Tshisekedi IsKilling	FARDC strikes on Minembwe; EU sanctions decision scheduled Mar 17; Doha meeting Mar 18	Sukhoi jets bombing Banyamulenge civilians; this is genocide; the UN and EU are complicit
4	Mar 19-21	26 / 8	#Tshisekedi IsKilling	Continued FARDC strikes after the Doha meeting	Minembwe airstrip destroyed deliberately; the only humanitarian lifeline is gone

Table 4. The four network waves and their diplomatic triggers. The timing of Wave 3 is the most operationally significant fact in the dataset: 121 posts on March 15 alone, two days before the EU Foreign Affairs Council voted on sanctions.

The timing of these waves is not incidental. Each corresponds closely to an external event that carried potential consequences for Rwanda, M23, or the Congolese government in international forums. The third wave is the most operationally significant: 121 posts were published on March 15 alone, two days before the European Union's Foreign Affairs Council voted on sanctions. The concentration of activity at this moment indicates a deliberate attempt to insert specific narratives into the information environment immediately preceding a decision point.

Narrative Architecture

Across the four waves, the network maintained three core narratives. Each closely corresponds to a position argued by Rwandan officials and M23/AFC spokespeople in formal diplomatic settings during the same weeks:

The first recasts President Tshisekedi from the leader of an invaded state into the sponsor of a genocidal militia, mirroring Kigali's standing justification for its military presence in the DRC. The second reframes FARDC airstrikes on the M23-aligned Twirwaneho-held Minembwe airfield as the aerial extermination of a civilian minority, reproducing almost point for point the March 10 statement of M23 president Bertrand Bisimwa. The genocide framing also performs a second function: it inverts the accusation most damaging to Kigali by making the DRC the genocidal actor. The third frames targets international actors directly, framing sanctions and diplomatic pressure as misdirected, punishing the party seeking peace while legitimising aggression.

The architecture is classic narrative laundering: take claims made by a state and by an armed group under sanction, strip the attribution, and re-voice them as the testimony of ordinary citizens addressed to international institutions.

Targeting Strategy

The network's distribution strategy was not oriented toward a broad audience reach but toward direct visibility within institutional channels. Of 612 posts, 181 tag both @UN and @EUCouncil, typically at the opening of the message, ensuring prominence in notification and monitoring systems.

Secondary targets include key DRC government's communicators and associated figures: First Lady @DeniseNyakeru (28 mentions, the anchor of Wave 1), government spokesperson @PatrickMuyaya (18), @Presidence_RDC (10), and Kinshasa-based journalist @StanysBujakera (8). In addition, 27 percent of network posts are replies placed directly beneath posts by DRC officials and pro-government influencers, embedding the network's messaging within existing conversation threads.

The network also engages in systematic hashtag contamination. A total of 190 network posts (31 percent) carry #CongolaisTelema, the DRC government's own mobilisation hashtag, alongside #TshisekediIsKilling. The intent is to contaminate the campaign's search surface: any user, journalist, or official who clicks the government's hashtag encounters genocide accusations against the government. 27 percent of network posts are replies planted under the posts of DRC officials and pro-government influencers.

Language choice provides a further indicator of the intended audience. Approximately 60 percent of network posts are in English, compared to 40 percent in French. This distribution contrasts sharply with organic Congolese discourse in the rdc tag, which is 94 percent French. A campaign aimed at domestic audiences would prioritise French, Lingala, Swahili, or Kinyarwanda. The predominance of English indicates that the intended readership lies outside the region, particularly within international policy and diplomatic communities.

Engagement and What It Does Not Measure

By every conventional metric the network failed to reach an organic audience. It accounted for 30 percent of the dataset's content and earned 2.1 percent of its views.

Median reach was 14 views per post; 67 percent of its posts received zero likes; 90 percent received fewer than 100 views.

Operation	Posts	Accounts	Total views	Median views/post	Posts with 0 likes
Anti-Tshisekedi network	612	90	71,695	14	67%
CongolaisTelema (rdc tag)	336	215	1,535,865	153	31%
Anti-Kagame flooder (single account)	152	1	36,621	200	37%
Other conflict tags (excl. flooder)	1,248	721	3,352,343	150	36%

Table 5. Engagement comparison across the three operations. The covert network's engagement collapse relative to even the single-account flooder is a structural feature, not incidental underperformance.

This pattern is not incidental underperformance but a structural feature of the operation. This collapse is explained by three features. First, the asset base is disposable: accounts with minimal follower counts lack any built-in amplification capacity. Second, there is no evidence of a secondary amplification layer; retweet activity is negligible (227 retweets across 612 posts). Third, the network does not attempt to present itself as locally embedded, with many accounts openly signalling Rwandan affiliation and posting primarily in English.

The operation's value to its sponsor, therefore, rests on two effects that engagement metrics do not capture: occupying the hashtag search surface, including the hijacked #CongolaisTelema, and placing content directly in front of the institutional accounts it tagged. An operation that places 181 genocide accusations in the mention feeds of @UN and @EUCouncil during a sanctions deliberation does not need a breakout to have done its job. It needs one staffer, one analyst, or one journalist to screenshot a post and ask, "Is there something to this?" in the wrong meeting.

Operation 2: The Anti-Kagame Hashtag Flooder

The rubavu collection tag (181 posts, 49 accounts) is dominated by a single account: RwandaN41033494, display name "African Truth Teller From Rwanda", declared location Nyagatare, Rwanda, 1,870 followers. This account alone produced 152 posts in the dataset, making it the single most prolific contributor in the entire collection.



Figure 4: a screenshot of an X (formerly Twitter) profile and bio.

Its method is mechanical and consistent. It reposts links to YouTube videos and broadcasts from international media (VOA Afrique, TV5 Monde, CNN News18, LCI, Africa 24, Newzroom Afrika) and from Rwandan opposition diaspora outlets (Radio Itahuka, Radio Inkingi, Radio Ubumwe), prefixed by the source name. It appends an unchanging block of thirteen hashtags:

#rubavu #gisenyi #rwanda #burundi #kigali #kinshasa #Africa #congo #goma #guerre #KagameIsKilling #KagameIsACriminal #RDFNefativeForce

The block appears in 109 of its 152 posts. The hashtags mix neutral geographic terms with attack hashtags, so that anyone searching for news about Rubavu, Gisenyi, or Goma is served anti-Kagame content. This is structurally identical to the covert network's hijacking of #CongolaisTelema, run in the opposite direction.

Attribution indicators point toward the Rwandan opposition diaspora rather than the Congolese state.

The account's bio advances the "double genocide" narrative associated with RNC/FDU Inkingi opposition messaging, and the outlets it amplifies (Radio Itahuka, Radio Inkingi) are diaspora opposition stations. Its posting tempo (152 posts over 21 active days, a median gap of about an hour, no machine-speed bursts) is consistent with a single committed individual rather than a staffed operation.

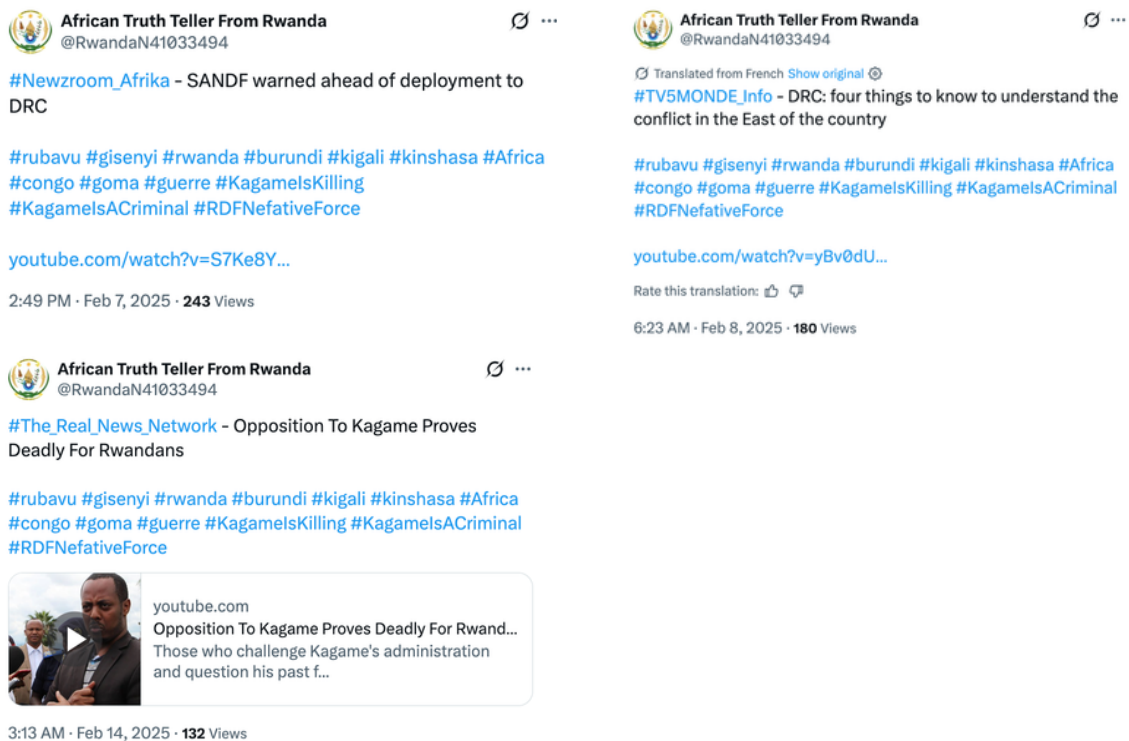


Figure 5: three screenshots of the flooder account

Its engagement is notable. With a median of approximately 200 views per post, it outperforms the entire 90-account covert network combined. A single, consistent operator posting at human pace achieved greater visibility than a coordinated network with burst-posting capability. The difference lies in discoverability: the flooder's content was indexed into widely searched geographic hashtags, while the network's content remained largely confined to its own narrower tagging strategy.

This account is analytically significant for two reasons. First, it demonstrates that the information space around this conflict is contested from multiple, ideologically opposed actors; treating all inauthentic behaviour in the dataset as a single operation would be an analytical error. Second, its technique (parasitising neutral geographic hashtags) is identical in kind to the covert network's hijacking of #CongolaisTelema, suggesting the technique is now simply part of the regional repertoire, available to any actor with patience and a grievance.

This case complicates a simple model of coordinated inauthentic behaviour as necessarily networked or state-directed. It shows that a single, persistent actor using basic distribution tactics can achieve comparable or greater reach than a structured operation, provided their content is embedded in high-visibility discovery pathways. In the context of conflict-era FIMI, effectiveness is not determined solely by scale or coordination, but by the ability to insert narratives into the informational routes that real audiences already use.

Operation 3: CongolaisTelema, the State Campaign

The rdc tag captures the Congolese government's own information campaign in the final week of March (with collection for this tag concentrated from March 22 to 30). CongolaisTelema is overt state communication: it is fronted by named officials, broadcast on state television, and tied to offline events including FARDC recruitment drives, provincial tours by Prime Minister Judith Suminwa, and concerts and slam poetry sessions of the "Front Culturel".

Overt status does not place it outside a FIMI analysis. State campaigns form the informational terrain that covert operations seek to exploit, and this campaign also exhibits its own forms of coordinated amplification that sit uneasily between standard political communication and inauthentic behaviour.

Layer	Accounts (examples)	Role	Reach
Government principals	@PatrickMuyaya (961K), @SuminwaJudith, @DeniseNyakeru	Set the message: unity, FARDC recruitment, cultural front, provincial tours	Muyaya's 5 posts drew 104,019 views; individual posts reach 12K-26K
State and party media	@acprdcongo (70K), RTNC, @pepele_news	Carry campaign events as news	ACP posted 12 times on Mar 30 alone
Verified journalist amplifiers	@StanysBujakera (823K), @wembi_steve (528K)	Republish campaign content, sometimes verbatim	Bujakera and Wembi together drew 516K views from 12 posts
Patriotic influencer tier	@kamba82, @beton_junior, @Princellunga14	High-frequency emotional amplification	61K-209K followers each; 1K-20K views per post

Table 6. CongolaisTelema campaign architecture by tier.

The campaign operates through a tiered architecture. At the top are government principals, @PatrickMuyaya, @SuminwaJudith, and @DeniseNyakeru, who define core messaging around national unity, military mobilisation, and civic participation. This content is then carried by state and party media accounts such as @acprdcongo and RTNC, which frame campaign activities as news. A third layer consists of verified journalists, including @StanysBujakera and @wembi_steve, who republish campaign messaging, in some cases verbatim, extending its reach to large established audiences. Finally, a “patriotic influencer” tier provides high-frequency, emotionally framed amplification, increasing visibility and repetition across the platform.

Two findings warrant emphasis. First, verbatim duplication: the same texts, including a government communique on M23 violations, coverage of the Prime Minister's Kenge stop, and a senator's Eid message, appear word for word across nominally independent journalist and influencer accounts. This indicates centrally distributed text being published as personal editorial content, a practice that sits on the border between press release journalism and astroturfing.



Figure 5: Posted in identical form by @TosuwaPaul and @chango_wa, March 22, 2025

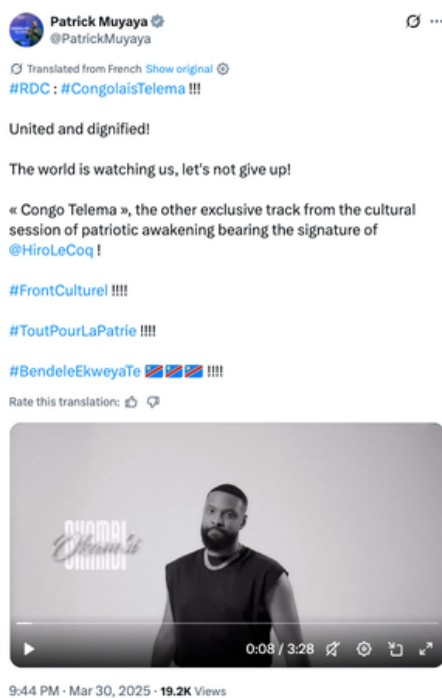


Figure 6: #CongolaisTelema in action from Congo's communications minister.

Second, the government's hashtag space was being used as a distribution channel by its adversaries in both covert and lightly disguised forms. The rdc tag also contains pro-M23 content seeded by the opposing side, including an identical post by three accounts celebrating M23 general Sultani Makenga in Goma. The campaign's 1.5 million views in its peak week was precisely what made it worth hijacking: a hashtag nobody searches is not worth contaminating.

Event Correlation: The Diplomatic Calendar as an Operational Clock

Date	Event	Dataset activity
Jan 2-17	Pre-offensive period	Pre-positioning: #DisarmFDLR and #TshisekediFDLR seeding begins (29 posts)
Jan 27	M23 and RDF take Goma	No immediate network surge; seeding continues
Feb 2-6	First Lady Nyakeru visits wounded FARDC soldiers; M23/RDF claim FDLR commanders killed	Wave 1: 143 posts / 12 accounts on #TshisekediFDLR; @DeniseNyakeru tagged 28 times
Feb 16	M23 takes Bukavu	No distinct wave; Struggles_23 and lisedes20 maintain baseline output
Feb 20-21	US sanctions Kabarebe and Kanyuka; UNSC adopts Resolution 2773	Quiet period; network re-tasking
Feb 24	EU Foreign Affairs Council postpones sanctions decision	Quiet
Feb 28-Mar 1	Week following Resolution 2773; EU sanctions pending	Wave 2: 145 posts / 20 accounts; six accounts activate within 2-hour window on Feb 28
~Mar 10-12	FARDC airstrikes on Minembwe airfield; M23 president Bisimwa accuses FARDC of bombing Banyamulenge civilians	Narrative material for Waves 3 and 4 enters circulation
Mar 15-16	Two days before EU sanctions vote; three days before Doha	Wave 3: 163 posts / 32 accounts on #TshisekediIsKilling; largest wave; every post addressed to @UN @EUCouncil
Mar 17	EU sanctions nine Rwandan and M23 officials; Rwanda severs diplomatic relations with Belgium	Network does not respond on the day
Mar 18	Tshisekedi and Kagame meet in Doha	Quiet
Mar 19-21	Continued FARDC strikes in Minembwe area	Wave 4: 26 posts / 8 accounts; Minembwe airstrip destruction narrative
Mar 22-30	PM Suminwa tours Kwango; SADC agrees withdrawal terms with M23	CongolaisTelema peak; Struggles_23 hijacks campaign hashtag through Mar 30

Table 7. Military and diplomatic events against information operation activity, January to March 2025. The correlation between network waves and institutional decision points is the core of the coordination finding.

Attribution Assessment

Attribution is assessed separately for each operation with explicit confidence levels.

Operation	Attribution Assessment	Confidence Level	Basis / Evidence
Anti-Tshisekedi Network	Coordinated inauthentic behaviour by a managed network	High	Machine-speed burst posting; stray master list numbering; synchronised multi-account activation windows; rotating per-wave hashtag tasking; templated content; disposable account inventory
	Aligned with Rwandan government and M23/AFC strategic messaging	High	Narrative alignment with Kigali/M23 positions; timing aligned with diplomatic decision points; Rwanda-linked account indicators; no deviation from pro-Rwanda framing across 612 posts
	Likely operated from Rwanda	Medium-High	Declared locations; language mix; RPF affinity markers
	Direct tasking by Rwandan state organ or contractor	Low-Medium	Behaviour indicates coordination tied to diplomatic calendar, but platform data cannot distinguish between state, contractor, or organised partisan actors
Anti-Kagame Flooder	Single-operator hashtag flooding activity (RwandaN41033494)	High	Consistent posting tempo; absence of coordination signals; uniform method and output pattern
	Likely aligned with Rwandan opposition diaspora (RNC/FDU Inkingi orbit)	Medium	Amplified outlets; “double genocide” framing in account bio
CongolaisTelema	Overt, centrally coordinated DRC government campaign	High	Named officials; linkage to offline events; structured multi-tier dissemination
	Use of inauthentic amplification practices	Medium-High	Verbatim duplication across nominally independent accounts; centrally distributed text published as personal content
	Use of paid amplification	Indeterminate	No direct evidence of financial coordination observable in dataset

Table 8: A summary of the attribution assessments for the operations.

This table summarises attribution assessments for the three identified operations, separating analytical judgments from confidence levels and the underlying behavioural evidence. It illustrates variation not only in likely sponsorship but also in organisational form, ranging from coordinated networks to single-actor activity and overt state communication incorporating hybrid amplification practices.

CONCLUSION

The Battlefield Was Brussels and New York

Propaganda, in its classical form, is a mass exercise. Saturate enough minds, shift the mood of a population, and you shift what governments feel they can do. The megaphone is its instrument. The crowd is its target.

What this investigation documents is not that model. It is a campaign that understood, with some precision, that the relevant battlefield for this conflict had migrated. The operation analysed here did not seek mass persuasion. It targeted a narrow set of institutional decision-makers, operating in a digital environment with minimal friction, where a small number of coordinated accounts, basic scripting, and precise timing were sufficient to insert narratives directly into the communication channels of the UN, EU and the Security Council.

That shift matters because the instincts for countering narrative manipulation were built for a different terrain. When the battleground was legacy media, the intervention point was the editor, the fact-checker, the broadcaster's standards desk. In the environment this operation exploited, none of those friction points exist. Content moves directly from operator to institutional mention feeds, at machine speed, at the precise moments calibrated to coincide with decision-making.

The standard instrument for rating an influence operation's impact is the Breakout Scale, developed by Ben Nimmo, which runs from Category 1 (an operation confined to one community on a single platform) to Category 6 (one that forces a policy response or a call to violence). On that scale, this network is a Category 1, and when read through the diffusion lens, the scale is built on, which looks like failure.⁴ This report argues that the Breakout Scale measures the wrong thing for this class of operation. The scale measures diffusion; diffusion was not the network's theory of victory. Its theory of victory was placement at decision points, and the scale has no instrument for that. As long as defenders keep using diffusion as the primary metric, operators targeting institutions get a free pass on the operations that matter most.

The Counter-Narrative Problem: Context, Not Correction

The prevailing response to influence operations is to identify falsehoods and correct them. That approach is poorly suited to this case because the content in question is not wholly fabricated.

The UN Group of Experts documents FARDC cooperation with FDLR elements. Anti-Tutsi violence in the DRC is real. The FARDC did bomb Minembwe, and Banyamulenge civilians do live there. The network's work was not fabrication. It was re-voicing: taking documented facts, stripping their context, removing attribution, and reassembling them into a picture that served a particular conclusion. The Minembwe airfield was a military target held by an M23-aligned armed group. That one fact, removed, turns an airstrike into a genocide. The operation did not invent the strike. It erased the context around it and re-addressed the remainder to the UN and EU as the testimony of ordinary citizens.

[4. The Breakout Scale: Measuring the impact of influence operations](#)

This pattern is not unique to conflict settings. During the Ebola outbreaks in eastern DRC, accurate information about infection clusters, mortality rates, and international response efforts was selectively reframed to support narratives of external manipulation or deliberate harm, contributing to distrust of health interventions. In both cases, the mechanism is the same: factual elements are preserved, but their meaning is altered through omission and recombination.⁵

This is precisely the type of manipulation the FIMI framework is designed to capture, and that a narrow “misinformation” framing misses. The issue is not simply false content, but the strategic re-voicing of selected truths through constructed personas.

The appropriate response is not fact-checking in isolation, but context restoration. This is slower, more resource-intensive, and dependent on local knowledge that is currently underdeveloped in the Great Lakes information environment. Every attempt to counter this network's content by labelling it false will fail, because the content is not false in every particular. It is true facts assembled into a false picture. The only thing that works is restoring the stripped context, and the only people who can do that reliably are those close enough to the conflict to know what the context is.

Hashtag Hijacking as Standard Infrastructure

A consistent structural feature of this case is that every campaign attacked every other campaign's hashtag. The pro-Rwanda network parasitised #CongolaisTelema. The anti-Kagame flooder parasitised #rubavu and #gisenyi. Pro-M23 content was seeded into the rdc tag.

This is not incidental. It reflects a structural condition of low-trust information environments”. Any high-visibility hashtag becomes a shared distribution channel. Visibility creates value, and value invites contamination. Campaigns designed to mobilise support simultaneously create vectors for adversarial insertion.

This has operational implications. Governments running mobilisation campaigns should plan for hashtag contamination from the outset. Platforms, in turn, could treat sudden semantic inversion within established tags, such as the sudden appearance of atrocity allegations within mobilisation campaigns, as detectable anomalies. At present, neither response is standard practice.

The Washington Accords and the Narrative Frame

In June 2025, nine months after the period this investigation covers, the United States brokered a peace agreement between the DRC and Rwanda, ratified in December as the Washington Accords. The agreement called for Rwandan troop withdrawal, DRC action against the FDLR, and a joint minerals framework opening eastern Congo's resources to US and Rwandan economic interests. As of mid-2026, Rwandan troops remain in the DRC, the FDLR has not been disbanded, and fighting continues. The deal has been criticised as one that addresses the interests of its brokers more directly than the causes of the conflict.

5. [Ebola and the Cartography of Distrust: When the Map of Fear Ignores the Map of the Virus](#)

This report does not establish a causal link between the observed information operations and that outcome. However, the narrative frame advanced during the March 2025 campaign, positioning the FDLR as the central problem, legitimising Rwanda's security posture, and depicting Tshisekedi as an obstacle, is recognisable in the structure of the subsequent agreement.

Whether this reflects direct influence on negotiations or a convergence with pre-existing geopolitical dynamics cannot be determined from this dataset. The alignment is, nonetheless, analytically relevant.

The Structural Gap

This entire operation ran during a war that displaced hundreds of thousands of people, on a platform whose trust and safety presence in the region is minimal, in an information environment where the journalists who would normally provide ground truth were being detained by the armed group whose narrative the operation amplified. Human Rights Watch documented M23's detention and intimidation of journalists and civil society activists in occupied Goma and Bukavu during precisely the weeks the network was most active, thinning the supply of independent reporting from the ground as the online campaigns intensified.

The asymmetry between the sophistication of the manipulation and the capacity of the defence is not incidental to this story. It is the story. European and North American FIMI frameworks, analyst networks, and rapid alert systems have no Great Lakes equivalent. The cost of that gap is paid in the quality of the international decisions the manipulation targets.

The operation ran at near-zero cost, required no infrastructure that is not commercially available, and left the external researcher working only from public signals. That is the operational environment this network exploited, and it remains almost entirely undefended.

Recommendations

Stakeholder	Recommended action	Priority
X (Trust and Safety)	Investigate the 90-account network for platform manipulation, leading with burst posting evidence, stray script numbers, and the Appendix A indicator list. Preserve registration, device, and IP data before any suspension so that attribution evidence is not destroyed by enforcement.	Immediate
X (Trust and Safety)	Build detection for the campaign's behavioural signatures: posts opening with institutional @ handles plus genocide lexicon; sustained posting above 2 posts per minute on conflict hashtags; semantic inversion within campaign hashtags.	Near term

Stakeholder	Recommended action	Priority
EU institutions and UN	Brief the delegations and social media teams that were targeted. They were addressed by name; they should know the provenance of the genocide messaging that reached their mention feeds during the week of the sanctions decision.	Immediate
EU institutions	Treat decision-point targeting as a FIMI category in EEAS threat reporting. The EU's FIMI framework is built for election interference; this case shows the same techniques aimed at Council decisions.	Near term
DRC government	Separate official campaign distribution from journalist amplification. Verbatim distribution of state text through nominally independent journalist accounts hands adversaries a credibility weapon and erodes the authority of the journalists involved.	Near term
Researchers	Cross-match this network's account roster against the Clemson Media Forensics Hub dataset to establish or exclude account-level continuity between the two documented RPF-aligned operations.	Near term
Funders and policy community	Invest in Great Lakes FIMI monitoring capacity: regional researchers, language coverage in French, Swahili, Lingala, and Kinyarwanda, and a rapid alert channel between regional civil society and the platforms and institutions being targeted.	Structural
All defenders	Monitor for reactivation of the same accounts at the next decision points (sanctions renewals, Doha and Washington process milestones). The network re-uses accounts across waves; the existing roster is a watchlist.	Ongoing

Table 8. Recommendations by stakeholders and priority.

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